



N.E.S.T.

NURTURING EDUCATION WITH SCHOOL & THERAPY

Speech Delay or Autism?

A Quick Reference Checklist

Telling the signs apart, side by side

SPEECH DELAY

Mostly about
the words

AUTISM

About the wider
social picture

Reviewed by Summaira Tariq, Director & Administration

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Signs That Lean Toward Each

This is a quick-reference tool, not a diagnosis. Many children show a mix of both columns — that overlap is exactly why a professional evaluation matters.

LEANS TOWARD SPEECH DELAY

- Still points and uses gestures to communicate
- Makes eye contact and shares attention with you
- Responds to their name consistently
- Enjoys back-and-forth play and imitation
- Understands much more than they can say
- Mainly behind on producing words, not on connecting

LEANS TOWARD AUTISM

- Limited eye contact or shared attention
- Not pointing or using gestures to request things
- Doesn't respond to name despite normal hearing
- Little interest in back-and-forth play or copying
- Repetitive movements or intense routines
- Repeats phrases (echolalia) rather than conversing

What about bilingual homes?

Growing up with Urdu, English, and a regional language does not cause autism or a language disorder. Bilingual children may blend languages or start talking a little later, but their total vocabulary across both languages is usually on track.

Why Guessing at Home Is Hard

Even experienced parents and teachers find it difficult to separate a speech delay from autism by observation alone — so much depends on subtle social cues easy to miss in daily life. A quiet child at a gathering, a tired toddler, or one deeply focused on a toy can be misread in either direction. Trained professionals use structured observation across different settings, which is far more reliable than a snapshot judgement.

- **Start with a hearing check.** Rules out a simple, fixable cause behind slow word growth.
- **Ask for a full developmental and speech-language assessment.** Looks at hearing, understanding, expressive language, and social communication together.
- **Don't wait it out indefinitely.** Early support has the strongest evidence of anything in this field, whichever the cause turns out to be.
- **Trust what you see day to day.** You know your child better than a single checklist ever could — bring your own observations to the assessment.

How N.E.S.T Can Help

Our certified speech-language pathologists (AAC Specialists) assess children ages 2 to 20, looking at hearing, understanding, expressive language, and social communication together. If autism is identified, our International Behavior Analyst (IBA) certified behavior therapists provide ABA therapy, alongside structured special education and speech support — all from one warm, unhurried team in DHA Phase 2, Islamabad.

BOOK AN ASSESSMENT

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